Colegio International de Caracas

STUDY GUIDE

JMUN 2026

DISEC

JMUN

Committee: Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC)

Topic: The use of Biological Weapons by Terrorist groups

1. **Letter from the Chair**

Dear Delegates, It is with great joy that I welcome you to JMUN 2026. My name is Andrea Torcat and I will be your chair of the Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC) for these two days. I'm honoured to guide you through what I believe is one of the most urgent and challenging issues facing international security today: the use of biological weapons by terrorist groups.

This topic requires careful analysis, responsibility, and cooperation. Biological weapons are especially dangerous because they can be used to cause fear, destabilization of societies, and overwhelm public health systems with relatively limited resources. In the hands of terrorist groups, these weapons become even more alarming, as non-state actors often seek not only destruction, but also panic, uncertainty. For that reason, this committee must focus on prevention, global cooperation, and strong international frameworks that protect both security and human life.

As Chair, I look forward to seeing thoughtful speeches, strong diplomacy, and very developed draft resolutions. Most importantly, I hope this committee becomes a space where delegates not only defend their country's position, but also work toward a safer and more secure world.

Iwish you all the best of luck.

Sincerely,

Andrea Torcat

Chair of DISEC

JMUN 2026

2. Country Matrix

Countries
Russia
Egypt
UK
Japan
Syria
USA
Germany
North Korea
Venezuela
South Sudan
Iran
Israel
Switzerland
Brazil
Oman
Austria

3. Committee introduction

The United Nations (UN) Disarmaments and International Security Committee (DISEC) was founded in 1945 after the ratification of the UN Charter under Chapter IV. It has its headquarters in New York and is one of the General Assembly's six main committees. It was established in response to the need for an international forum that addresses security and peace concerns among the members of the United Nations to prevent irreparable harm to the world after the Second World War. It was established at the Yalta Conference, where Winston Churchill, Franklin D. Roosevelt, and Joseph Stalin gathered to discuss the restructuring of Europe, especially Germany. The main goal was to create a postwar plan to grant self-determination to the liberated people of Europe and during the Cold War it focused on striking a balance between capitalism and communism. All 193 UN members are automatically eligible to serve as representatives in DISEC's body and have an equal vote, according to article 9 of the UN Charter. Following the events in Hiroshima and Nagasaki, the first resolution was put to a vote in 1946. The Committee was divided into three primary sections: The General Debate, the Thematic Discussion, and Action plans or Drafts. The committee meets to discuss current issues under its mandate, such as the use of nuclear weapons, other weapons of mass destruction, disarmaments agreements, and regulation of conventional weapons.

4. Topic Introduction

The term biological weapon describes an organism such as living cells or toxins, bacteria or viruses, that are deliberately used to produce diseases, death, or produce panic in a society. The deliberate acquisition or attempted use of biological weapons by terrorist groups is known as bioterrorism, a type of warfare capable of generating enormous amounts of fear, causing immense economic disasters, and creating public health crises with minimal resources. The United Nations generally describes terrorism as "criminal acts intended or calculated to provoke a state of terror in the general public, a group of persons or specific persons for political purposes," and emphasizes that such acts need to be prevented regardless of the motives. The Biological Weapons Convention explicitly aims to "exclude completely the

possibility of bacteriological (biological) agents and toxins being used as weapons," which includes non-state actors as well.

For this conference, the focus of the delegates should not fall on typical state-to-state biological warfare, but rather on the following points:

- How terrorist groups gain access biological agents
- How states can prevent their acquisition and misuse
- And finally, how international cooperation can reduce the risk of these non-state actors obtaining these toxins. .

Therefore, delegates should explore action plans that include national biosecurity, knowledge sharing cooperation, international controls, and legal frameworks both nationally and internationally and counter-attack military operations.

5. Key terms

Biological weapon: Any biological agent such as bacteria, viruses, toxins, or any type of infected vector that is used to cause disease or death in humans, animals, or plants for hostile purposes. Bioterrorism: The intentional use of biological agents by terrorist groups to cause harm, terror, or political pressure. Dual-use research: Scientific research that can be used for peaceful purposes like vaccines or agriculture security but could also be misused for weapons development. BWC (Biological Weapons Convention): The Convention on the Prohibition of the Development, Production and Stockpiling of Biological and Toxin Weapons and on their Destruction (1972), which bans biological weapons for state parties. Non-state actors: Individuals or groups that are not officially involved with the government of a country, such as terrorist groups. Proliferation: This word is used to describe the spread of mass destruction weapons to non-state actors. Rogue states: In this context, this term refers to countries that may not openly be supportive of non-actors working with biological or chemical weapons, but might tolerate using these arms as a strategic way of achieving a political goal. Precursor: Substance that is required to make a toxic agent. The precursors are usually combined with other substances in order to get a desired toxic chemical. UN Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004): A binding resolution under Chapter VII that obliges all states to prevent non-state actors from acquiring nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons and their means of delivery.

6. Topic

6.1 History of the topic

From a historical perspective, ideas about using diseases as weapons have long dominated modern terrorism, but the specific concern about biological weapons in the hands of non-state actors is relatively recent and closely linked to twentieth-century developments in science, war, and international law. Early examples of biological warfare involved states or armies rather than clandestine groups: during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, European powers reportedly used smallpox-contaminated materials and other diseases to weaken opponents, illustrating how infectious agents could be manipulated for strategic gain. In the twentieth century, major military programs, in particular those of Japan, the Soviet Union, and the Western powers transformed biological warfare from crude methods into industrial scale research and potential battlefield use, creating a large pool of expertise, pathogens, and dual-use infrastructure that would later worry policymakers when they considered terrorist threats. Due to this in 1925 the Geneva Protocol prohibited the use of biological and chemical weapons in war, but it did not address research, production, or the activities of non-state actors, and many state programs continued in secret for decades. During the Cold War, both superpowers and several other states expanded or maintained biological capabilities despite growing public and diplomatic pressure, which culminated in the 1972 Biological Weapons Convention (BWC). The BWC was the first multilateral treaty to comprehensively ban the development, production, and stockpiling of biological and toxin weapons, reflecting a consensus that these arms were uniquely destabilizing and ethically unacceptable. However, the convention lacked strong verification mechanisms, and later discoveries, such as the Soviet Union's large covert bioweapons program, demonstrated that the state's persisted to ignore the agreements, which reinforces the fear that expertise or materials might someday leak to non-state actors or be deliberately shared. The specific notion of "bioterrorism" emerged as terrorism itself devolved in the late twentieth century. In the 1970s and 1980s, most terrorist organizations relied on firearms, hijackings, and explosives, and analysts often argued that these groups preferred methods that were predictable, controllable, and immediately visible. Biological agents, in contrast, are invisible, difficult to handle safely, and can produce delayed or uncertain effects, which initially discouraged many groups from experimenting with them. Nonetheless, isolated plots appeared: small extremist or apocalyptic movements showed interest in poisons and pathogens, and some tried to culture or disperse them on a limited scale. These attempts were usually technically unsophisticated and largely unsuccessful, but they proved that the conceptual barrier to using disease as a terror tool could be crossed. The 1990s marked a turning point due to both major incidents that shifted the perceptions of non-state actors. The most famous case is the Japanese cult Aum Shinrikyo, which invested

significant resources in efforts to develop biological weapons, including attempts to obtain and disseminate anthrax and botulinum toxin, alongside its chemical attacks. Although its biological attacks failed due to technical errors, the scale of its ambition shocked governments and experts, showing that a determined non-state actor could recruit scientists, buy equipment, and conduct weapon-related experiments. At the same time, advances in molecular biology, genetic engineering, and the spread of commercial laboratory tools made it easier for smaller organizations or skilled individuals to work with dangerous microbes. The 2001 anthrax letter attacks in the United States, which followed shortly after the 11 September terrorist attacks, further transformed the global debate. Although the perpetrator in that case appears to have been an individual with specialized access rather than a formal terrorist group, the event illustrated the political and psychological impact that even a small-scale biological release could have: postal systems were disrupted, public offices were evacuated, and there was widespread fear far beyond the actual number of infections. Governments began to invest heavily in biodefense, disease surveillance, and public-health preparedness, treating bioterrorism as a core security issue rather than a hypothetical risk. International organizations, including the UN and the World Health Organization, started to integrate terrorism scenarios into their discussions of health emergencies and response coordination. In recent decades, concern has grown that terrorist groups could exploit natural outbreaks or emerging technologies rather than relying solely on classic agents like anthrax or plague. Some extremist organizations have discussed using contagious diseases, have tried to weaponize toxins, or have called on followers to spread pathogens deliberately during pandemics, often with limited practical success but significant propaganda value. At the same time, synthetic biology and gene editing have expanded the range of theoretically possible modifications to organisms, from enhancing virulence to altering host ranges, which complicates verification and control under existing treaties. For DISEC and the broader UN system, this history underscores that the threat of biological weapons use by terrorist groups is inseparable from state behavior, scientific progress, and the strength of global health systems. It also shows that effective responses must combine arms control, counterterrorism, public-health preparedness, and responsible innovation to reduce both opportunity and motivation for such attacks.

6.2 Discussion of the topic

6.2.1 Existing Legal Frameworks

The main legal frameworks are the ones established by the BWC and the UNSC 1540 resolution, that require each state to:

- Prohibit the development, production, and stockpiling of biological weapons
- Punish any attempts by non-state actors to acquire or use biological weapons
- Establish national laws that control the use of biological agents, existing laboratories, and materials of risk.

The implementation of these laws, however, has faced some challenges, as the compliance and enforcements from the nations remains uneven. Some states have not fully adapted the BWC frameworks into their national law, and others simply lack the ability to monitor all biological materials in their nation. This is intensified by the absence of a formal control body under the BWC jurisdiction, making it even more difficult to prevent non-state actors from secretly developing biological weapons.

6.2.2 Motivations of Terrorist Groups

In the majority of cases, terrorist organizations seek high impact, low attribution, and high destructive effect, both psychologically and tangibly. Biological weapons align perfectly with this goals because:

- A single effective release can cause widespread illnesses and terror
- The attribution of culpability can be delayed or uncertain due to the complexity of tracing the origin of the disease
- Laboratories or development facilities can be small and easy to hide from authorities.

As we know, non-state actors have attempted to use biological weapons to terrorise societies, like the 1984 Rajneeshee salmonella poisoning in the United States, and have allegedly tried to acquire Anthrax and other pathogens.

7. Block Positions

Block 1: Enforcement Block

Countries:

- United States
- United Kingdom
- Germany
- Japan
- Switzerland
- Austria
- Israel

Characteristics: High national implementation of the BWC and UNSC Resolution 1540 articles, higher control on biological materials and exporting materials, efforts in strengthening international cooperation and intelligence sharing.

Block 2: Sovereignty Concerned Block

Countries:

- Russia
- Egypt Syria
- North Korea
- Iran
- Venezuela
- South Sudan
- Oman Brazil
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Characteristics: these nations recognises the importance of the BWC for global security but insists that efforts to strengthen it should be non-intrusive and consensus based, these delegations should focus on preventing double standards in how non-western states are inspected, ensuring any resolution does not undermine the right of sovereignty, and reinforcing counter attack efforts in regions affected by conflict.

8. **Previous attempts to solve the problem Strengthening the BWC** Members of the BWC have held every five years Review Conferences to assess the implementation of the rules, encourage states to adopt national legislations, urged states to submit biological research to gather collective knowledge, and discuss possible new verification mechanisms, however, these attempts of verification have been blocked due to US opposition, which has caused the BWC to be left without a formal inspection system.

9. **Guiding questions**
    - How can the international community prevent terrorist organizations from accessing biological agents or dual-use materials?
    - Should the focus be on stronger global verification, or on national implementation and intelligence-sharing?\
    - What should be done about states with weak border control, poor laboratory security, or ongoing conflict?
    - How can the UN respond if a terrorist attack using biological material actually occurs?

10. **Relevant UN Treaties and Further Reading**

- Biological Weapons Convention (BWC), 1972: UNODA – BWC
- UN Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004): https://www.un.org/en/sc/1540/1540-fact-sheet.shtml
- UN General Assembly Resolution on the BWC
- UN General Assembly Resolution on the UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy (75/291, 2021):
- Reports of the 1540 Committee and the BWC States-Parties meetings:

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